# Case Study 1 - Atari

## Student submission

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**Worksheet link**

https://courses.ethereallab.app/assignment/v4/IT265-001-F2026/case-study-1-atari/psj22

**Grading link**

https://courses.ethereallab.app/assignment/v4/IT265-001-F2026/case-study-1-atari/grading/psj22

AI disclosure: Completed; 1 entry; 0 declared AI use; 1 declared no AI use; policy v1

# Game Overview

## Game details

### Response prompt

Identify the game: title, developer, publisher, original platform, genre, and release date. Note the version you played if different.

### Submitted response

Title: The Amazing Spider-Man
Developer: Oxford Digital Enterprises
Publishers: Paragon Software (in North America) and Empire Interactive (in Europe)
Original Platform(s): Commodore 64 and Amiga
Genre: Platformer
Release date: 1990

## History and industry

### Response prompt

Explain the historical context of the release and where the game fit in the industry at that time.

### Submitted response

At this point in time, the Toby Maguire Spider-Man movies didn't exist yet, despite the game's levels being themed around movies and movie studios. It was also full of pop culture references of the time including famous people (like singers and politicians) and TV shows. Despite being released at a time where home consoles were very popular, this game was one of many forgettable games released.

## Contemporary comparison

### Response prompt

Compare the game with a similar game from the same period, explaining a meaningful design similarity or difference.

### Submitted response

While it is technically of the platformer genre like Super Mario Bros. 3 (1990), they have very different gameplay. Mario is more about traversal, jumping, and killing enemies, while Spider-Man is more so puzzle solving and webbing up enemies.

# Gameplay Mechanics And Level Design

## Core gameplay mechanics

**Response prompt**

Explain how the core actions and rules shape a recurring player decision. Support the explanation with a gameplay example.

**Submitted response**

Sometimes, in order to traverse certain rooms, you have figure out if you have to pull yourself towards a location with a web, crawl, or just walk. You can't make a web while crawling, but you can't freely detach yourself from walls or stand-up while horizontal. You also can't crawl without a wall or ceiling so you have to figure out a sequence and position yourself to efficiently clear a room.

### Level design

**Response prompt**

Explain how the layout, obstacles, or progression affect a player decision or challenge. Use a specific example.

**Submitted response**

Sometimes, there are switches that don't let you progress unless multiple are in the right combination, there's some switches that can only be activated with a web, there's also green surfaces  which are slippery and unclimbable. As well as sometimes you have to back track to past rooms to progress after flipping a switch.

## Graphic And Audio Design

### Visual design

**Response prompt**

Explain how a visual design choice affects the experience or communicates information during play. Use a specific example.

**Submitted response**

Green surfaces are slippery and you can't walk or climb on green surfaces. This is weird because green usually means good or toxic depending on how it's presented.

### Sound design

**Response prompt**

Explain how music, sound effects, or their absence affect the experience or communicate information during play. Use a specific example.

**Submitted response**

The background music makes me feel like I'm sneaking around. Other than that, there's not a whole lot of sound effects that indicate things as far as I've gotten.

## Narrative And Storytelling

### Narrative and setting

**Response prompt**

Explain how the setting and story relate to play. Describe key events if present, or explain the effect of a limited or absent story.

**Submitted response**

The game takes place in a movie studio with the premise being Mysterio (one of Spider-Man's rogues) has kidnapped Mary Jane (Spider-Man's wife) and is holding her hostage. In the early game, this isn't exactly made known, unless if at the start, you go out of your way to go on top of the building where the game takes place and you can see Mysterio holding Mary Jane hostage.

### Character development

#### Response prompt

Explain how character development relates to gameplay, or how limited or absent development affects the experience.

#### Submitted response

There isn't a lot of character development, given it's a 1990's superhero video game, it's mostly just framed as just another adventure for our hero. You get to be Spider-Man!

## Impact And Reception

### Reception

#### Response prompt

Summarize the critical and player reception using identifiable reviews or feedback. Distinguish release-era reception from later reactions.

#### Submitted response

Both release-era ratings and later reactions share a common sentiment: It was certainly a choice to make a game about every child's favorite superhero a puzzle-solving platformer as a opposed to an action beat-em-up game. With that said, the game is clunky but gets easier as you get used to the gameplay flow. Decent visuals as well. People liked the brainteasers, but not the clunky controls.

### Industry and cultural impact

#### Response prompt

Explain the game's industry impact and cultural significance using research. Avoid claiming influence that the sources do not establish.

#### Submitted response

While the game wasn't groundbreaking by any means (like at all, it's considered one of the weakest Spider-Man games), it did inspire more developers to adapting other superheroes and even had some sequel games.

## Reflection

### Fun and experience

#### Response prompt

Explain what made the game enjoyable or frustrating for you, using a gameplay example.

#### Submitted response

Once I figured out the early puzzles, it became enjoyable to do them faster, but the clunky controls do hurt my opinion of it. As well having to constantly go back and forth between rooms trying to understand what I'm meant to do. It was also frustrating where if I messed up traversing a specific area, I have to go back the full way again from an earlier room. Overall, not the worst game in the world, it had some interesting aspects like the rooms with different gravity and finding ways to avoid enemies rather than defeating most of them.

### Learning and research

#### Response prompt

Reflect on what this case study taught you and how easy or difficult it was to find dependable information.

#### Submitted response

There is not a whole lot of easy to find information about the history of these lesser known retro games.